Hard house

Chelonian shells are made of a dome-shaped top and a flatter shield under the belly. Both parts are made up of bony plates. The surface of the shell is covered in large scales called scutes.



Domed top (carapace).

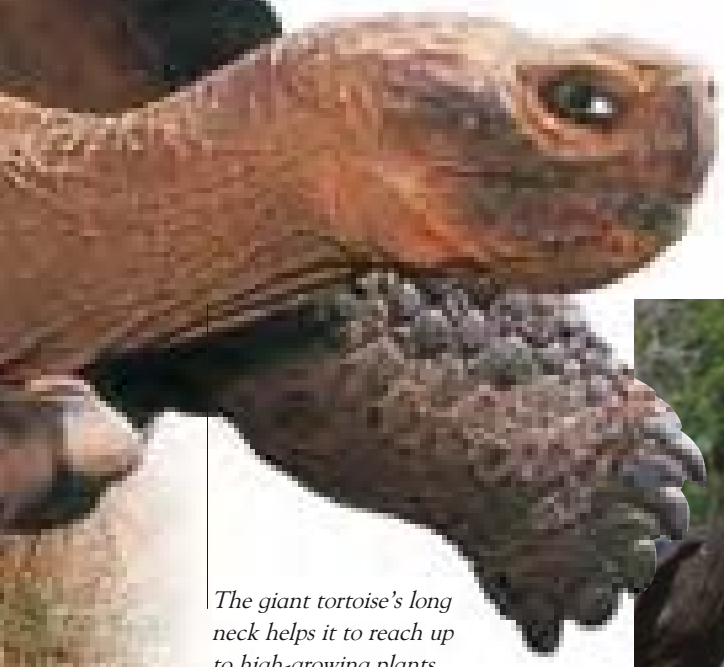
Shielded belly (plastron).

Bottoms up!

Turtles push their heads above water to take in air, but can also breathe underwater. They do this by taking air in through their skin, the lining of their throat, and also through a small hole near their bottom!



European pond turtle



The giant tortoise's long neck helps it to reach up to high-growing plants.



Heads up!

Most *Chelonians* are able to pull their heads back into their shells for protection. If involved in a squabble, they bring their heads right out to show their anger.

These two giant tortoises are having a little argument.

Shell suits

The shells are needed for self-defense. High-arched and knobby shells give protection from bad weather and predators. Shells that blend into the natural surroundings can also help to disguise tortoises and turtles.



Snake-neck turtle

Starred tortoise

Alligator snapping turtle

Pond turtle (terrapin)